



Jerome Saigot
MD, Nissan Motor India

INDIA'S NEXT BIG SHIFT

Automatic Gearboxes

The evolving preferences of Indian car buyers are translating to more sophisticated automatic transmission technologies.

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The Indian automotive industry is going through a clear paradigm shift, with more auto companies promoting automatic gearboxes. While the luxury and premium segments have always been equipped with auto 'boxes, it is the budget segment that is showing stronger affinity towards cars equipped with automatic gearboxes, clear indicators of which can be seen with the wide range of AMT-equipped cars. Honda even went a step further with its all-new second generation Honda Amaze, which features a CVT gearbox in the sub-four metre compact sedan category. The reasons for this can be attributed to

two key areas - increasing congestion on roads and the subsequent inconvenience of continuously having to shift gears, and a more mature segment of car buyers opting for greater value for money and convenience. These are the very factors that were highlighted in our conversation with Mr. Jerome Saigot, Managing Director, Nissan Motor India Pvt. Ltd. So, how is the trend panning out, and what lies ahead in the future of mainstream cars in India?

The next big shift

As with every big technology, automatic gearboxes have seen clear preference in the premium car

segments of India. Now, with time, these technologies are trickling down towards the more affordable segments. Saigot highlights, "Today, AMT has transformed the way consumers look at technology. Apart from heavily congested roads, cars which are equipped with AMT gear ratios makes driving considerably comfortable and reduces the fatigue level of the driver during bumper to bumper traffic movement. Shift in buying decisions are also influenced by declining cost differential between manual and automatic gearbox, owing to maturity in technology."

The factor of congestion on Indian roads has been highlighted across multiple conferences, which include Ford's City of Tomorrow symposium held last year in New Delhi, India. The Indian population demographic in urban cities is steadily making a shift towards more developed buying decisions, buoyed by higher spending abilities and increasing awareness of multiple propositions in one segment. Even this is divided into multiple points based on demands and categories, which then define a rising trend. For the mainstream cars in India, it is the rise of automatic gearboxes.

Saigot explains, "We have seen a very positive and significant change in